relating to the crisis.[63] Scholars at Harvard and Brown Universities sponsored a series of conferences that brought together participants from Cuba, the United States, and the USSR to discuss the newly declassified documents, and to try to arrive at a new synthesis. This wave of analysis was decidedly less celebratory than the scholarship of the first decades after the crisis, with the major players in the United States emerging as more foolhardy than heroic.[64]

The 1990s saw an unprecedented openness for historians of the Missile Crisis, adding to the declassification of U.S. documents the opening of Soviet and Cuban archives.[65] Two major conferences in Havana, on the 30th anniversary of the crisis in 1992, and on the 40th anniversary in 2002, brought together scholars and participants to further debate and clarify some of the major historical questions. Perhaps to the surprise of the earlier generation of Cold War scholars, many of the claims made by the Soviets and the Cubans, previously denied by U.S. sources, turned out to be true. The Cubans did fear another U.S. invasion, and in fact plans for such an invasion were in the works. Soviet nuclear capability was in fact far behind what the United States had developed. U.S. officials knew that placing operational missiles near Soviet borders, in Turkey and Italy, augmented the imbalance. The Soviet purpose of placing missiles in Cuba was to address real threats: to defend Cuba against U.S. attack and to respond to the global strategic and political nuclear advantage held by the United States. The Soviets agreed to withdraw the missiles not because of Kennedy's steely resolve, but because the United States agreed to Soviet demands that it relinquish its plans to invade Cuba – which it did publicly – and that it remove the missiles in Turkey, which it agreed to privately. (Until the release of the declassified documents, U.S. officials roundly denied that any deal had been made with the Soviets.) Khrushchev was shaken, not by Kennedy's strength of will, but by his recklessness and the real threat the U.S. stance posed of nuclear destruction.

Despite U.S. promises, it refused to accept international oversight of its non-intervention pledge, and in fact U.S. attempts to overthrow the